

Editorial

Smart Cards, Dumb Bureaucrats

AS YOU TRAVEL along the lunar stretch that connects Pune to Mumbai—euphemistically called a highway—you come across the first toll booth at a place called Vashi. In August, the people who levy toll on this road, decided to introduce smart cards to make things easier.

Until July, vehicle owners would stick an ugly, fluorescent sticker on their car's windscreen. It was their monthly toll pass.

So when smart cards were introduced in August, there was some jubilation. The toll contractors installed spanking new PCs, printers, and a smart card system, thereby ending the Ugly Sticker regime.

Or so the commuters thought.

Earlier, the man who handed out the sticker noted your vehicle registration number in a log book, returned the change, and then wrote the registration number on the sticker. This routine took not more than 45 to 60 seconds.

You'd think the smart card would make it easier. But here is what happens: The same man now notes the vehicle registration number in his log book, and later onto the computer, extracts a smart card from his filing cabinet, puts a sticker on it, and writes the vehicle registration number on the sticker. He then goes back to the PC, and prints out a receipt. Once this is done, he returns the change and hands you the smart card. Time taken: five minutes. Result: Delayed service, long queues, and more than 5,000 agonised commuters.

One hundred marks for transparency, zero for efficiency.

After spending lakhs on thousands of smart cards (priced at Rs 70 each, a cost passed on to commuters), Pentium 4 PCs, four dot matrix printers, and a smart card authenticator, Mumbai's outbound commuters are still stuck with a sticker (every month one more sticker will be stuck to the previous one), and now they even have to remember to carry the smart card every day, which, for all practical purposes, is a dog tag, because the authorities have not installed a card reader at the toll booth.

The Vashi toll booth is a perfect example of how technology is used where none is required—or even if needed, how bureaucrats tend to over-engineer solutions instead of using a little common sense. The ugly



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sticker, however undesirable, was a reasonably comfortable solution, especially in resource-poor India.

Admittedly, smart cards need to proliferate in the economy, but can only do so if the infrastructure is in place. One that will allow not only easy passage at Vashi (or any other toll booth in India), but also serve as a card for cashless transactions at multiple points—supermarkets, petrol pumps, ration offices, or when dealing with government departments. It can make the transactions cleaner, and prevent corruption to a certain degree.

Only then would smart cards have truly touched our lives.

We shall wait for that day.

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